

MAGIC EFFECTS

There are thousands of different magic tricks and magicians are always thinking up new ones. All magicians perform their magic using effects. The simplest tricks rely on just one effect, but more complicated tricks use several effects at once.



PRODUCTION

Making something – or someone – appear out of nowhere.



VANISHING

The opposite of production – making a thing or person disappear.



LEVITATION OR SUSPENSION

Making something or someone appear to fly or float in midair.



PREDICTION

Seeming to know what is about to happen, such as which card will be picked.



TRANSFORMATION

Changing one thing into something else, such as a person into an animal.



RESTORATION

"Magically" repairing a torn or broken object.



ESCAPOLOGY

Escaping from restraints such as handcuffs, or traps such as cages.



TELEPORTATION

Moving something from one place to another without seeming to handle it.

MAGIC SKILLS

Entertaining the audience is a magician's first task. Once the audience is under his or her spell, the magician uses sleight of hand – distraction and deception – to make it appear that real magic is being performed.



SHOWMANSHIP

A good magician amuses and entertains the audience. Props such as scarves come in useful, and so does " patter" – telling jokes or asking questions.



SLEIGHT OF HAND

The magician takes advantage of "blind spots" in the audience's vision and uses fast, fluid hand movements to hide or disguise an action.

MAGICIANS

The first stars of stage magic invented their own amazing tricks. Today's top magicians continue this tradition, devising different illusions to delight and enthrall audiences.

THE GREAT LAFAYETTE (1871–1911)

Lafayette was probably the most successful magician of his time. His speciality was dramatic illusions, often performed with his dog Beauty, a gift from Harry Houdini.

HARRY HOUDINI (1874–1926)

The greatest escapologist the world has ever known, Houdini could free himself from anything – handcuffs, leg irons, cages, straitjackets, prison cells, and even a sealed milk can.



HOUDINI

DANTE THE GREAT (1883–1955)

Dante's amazing shows of tricks and illusions included a huge cast of musicians, jugglers, acrobats, birds, and animals.

CRISS ANGEL (1967–)

"Magician of the Century" Criss Angel's stunts include walking on water, floating between two buildings, making an elephant disappear, and being run over by a steamroller while lying on a bed of glass.

DAVID BLAINE (1973–)

Blaine performs amazing feats of endurance such as being encased in ice, buried alive, or surrounded by deadly electric currents.

RAISING ACES

This teleportation trick makes it look as though you can conjure up the aces from a pack of cards. Carry out the first step in secret, then ask for a volunteer.



1 PREPARE THE DECK

Remove all four aces and place them on the top of the pack face down.



2 FOUR PILES

Ask your volunteer to divide the pack into four roughly equal piles. Keep track of which pile contains the aces.



3 TOP THREE CARDS

Ask the volunteer to choose one of the three piles that don't contain the aces. Get him or her to take the top three cards and move them to the bottom of the pile.



4 DEAL ONE CARD

Have your volunteer deal one card from their pile on to each of the other three piles. Then repeat this for the other piles without aces, and finally for the pile with aces.



5 REVEAL THE ACES

Ask your volunteer to turn over the top card of each pile to reveal the four aces.

HEAT IS ON

This coin trick uses the effect of prediction to make your audience believe you have hidden mind-reading powers. You will need a bag of cool coins – put the coins in the fridge for a few minutes before you start.



1 GATHER THE AUDIENCE

Ask an audience member to pick a coin from the bag, hold it tightly and think hard about its appearance.



2 MIX THEM UP

Ask your volunteer to put the coin back in the bag, then tip out all the coins.



3 MISLEAD THE AUDIENCE

Pick up each coin and look at it, pretending to concentrate hard.



4 SHOW THE COIN

The coin that is warm to the touch is the one your volunteer picked up, of course!

THE MAGIC STRING

This trick uses the effect of restoration to appear to make a cut piece of string whole again. You will need a short length and a longer length of string and scissors.



1 SHORT STRING

Take the short length of string and hide it in the palm of your left hand.



2 LONG STRING

Place the longer length in your left hand below the shorter, so the shorter loop sticks out.



3 CUT THE STRING

Ask a volunteer to cut through the loop that's sticking out.



4 HIDE IT

Secretly tuck the cut pieces into the palm of your hand and pull out the long string.



5 RESTORE THE STRING

Show your audience the long string while keeping the shorter length hidden in your hand.